

worked for the firm and who did their part in helping to win the War. I stayed on at Spartan until 1948 to nurse the firm through the pangs of reconversion to peacetime production of house trailers. Then once more I went back to my first and greatest business love— oil.

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My oil companies were prospering and were larger and more active than ever before, but it was time for additional expansion. Vast demands had been made on America's oil reserves by the War, and post-War petroleum consumption was rising sharply throughout the world. Oil prospectors were fanning out—to Canada, Central and South America, Africa and the Middle East—searching for new oil sources.

Instinct, hunch, luck—call it what you will—told me the Middle East was the most promising locale, the best bet, for oil exploration. I had almost obtained an oil concession in the Middle East in the 1930s, but had allowed my chance to go by. Now I decided to seek a concession to prospect and drill there and make up for the opportunity I had lost. In February 1949, Getty interests obtained a 60-year concession on a half interest in the so-called Neutral Zone, an arid, virtually uninhabited and barely explored desert region lying between Saudi Arabia and Kuwait on the Persian Gulf.

The concession was granted by His Majesty, Ibn Saud, king of Saudi Arabia. In immediate consideration for the right to explore and drill for oil in the Neutral Zone, the Saudi Arabian Government received \$12,500,000. It was a gargantuan risk and many people in the petroleum industry once again openly predicted I would bankrupt my firms and myself.

Four years and \$18,000,000 were needed before we brought in our first producing well in the Neutral Zone.

But, by 1954, I could relax and enjoy a private last laugh at the expense of those who had prophesied my ruin. The Neutral Zone has proved to be one of the world's most valuable oil properties. Well after well has come in and petroleum geologists conservatively estimate proven

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